JUNE 9-10, 2026 • SOUTH SAN FRANCISCO CONFERENCE CENTER

HR WEST

HRWest Agenda

View Online

Day 1 - June 9, 2026

JUN 9, 2026
8:30 am - 9:05 am PT
HR Strategy/AI
Main Stage

Welcome to HRWest 2026!

Welcome to HRWest 2026! In this opening session, Yael Schy and Jason Averbook will welcome attendees and set the tone for a conference built on community, learning, and shared growth as we work together to Rise Above the Fog.

PRESENTERS:

Debbie McGrath
CEO / Founder and Chief Instigator
HR.com

Jason Averbook
Co-Founder
Now to Next

Yael Schy
Founder
Zoomers to Boomers Improv

JUN 9, 2026
9:10 am - 10:00 am PT
HR Strategy/AI
Main Stage

The AI-First HR Function: Strategy, Structure, and Systems

This is an immersive, hands-on workshop for HR leaders to gain the education and inspiration needed to produce a clear vision and scalable strategies for enabling AI for workforce and business outcomes. Attendees will get a clear understanding of the different types and applications of AI in workforce technologies, a framework for deployment, success, and a scaled approach for realizing business value.

PRESENTERS:

Jason Averbook
Co-Founder
Now to Next

JUN 9, 2026
10:00 am - 10:45 am PT
HR Strategy/AI
Exhibit Hall

Expo Time, Coffee Break and Intro to Replit

Take this time to visit the exhibit hall to learn about the latest HR solutions, grab some coffee, and hear a brief demo from Replit. It's the perfect opportunity to reconnect with HR friends and make new connections.

PRESENTERS:

Stacey La Torre
Chief People Officer
Replit

JUN 9, 2026
10:45 am - 11:15 am PT
Leadership
Baden 2

Rethinking Leadership in Modern Organizations

Most organizations don't have a retention problem—they have a leadership blind spot. Leaders often make assumptions about why employees stay or leave without ever truly understanding their people.

In this session, Natalie Grabher challenges common misconceptions around retention and performance, showing why hiring is not a quick fix but a long-term investment with delayed return. She will break down the real cost of hiring, the importance of structured performance management, and how SMART goals create clarity and accountability.

Natalie also explores how AI can eliminate time-consuming administrative work, allowing leaders to reinvest that time where it matters most—building genuine relationships with their teams. Attendees will leave with practical strategies to lead more intentionally, improve retention, and turn people management into a measurable business advantage.

PRESENTERS:

Natalie Grabher
VP of HR
Hall of Frames

JUN 9, 2026
10:45 am - 11:15 am PT
Legal and Compliance
Oyster Room

The 2026 Workplace Reset: Employment Law Shifts Employers Can't Ignore

This interactive session will tackle some of the most challenging areas for in-house counsel and HR professionals in 2026, including the latest developments on remote-work accommodations and leave requests, as well as updates on new "stay-or-pay" restrictions that every practitioner should know. In addition, we will discuss the newly issued independent-contractor guidelines and what to watch out for under the newly constituted NLRB.

PRESENTERS:

Holly Sutton
Co-Managing Partner
Farella Braun + Martel LLP

JUN 9, 2026
10:45 am - 11:15 am PT
HR Strategy/AI
Main Stage

The Road Ahead: Predictions and Possibilities for the Future of Work

The future of work will not follow a single path—multiple, competing futures are already emerging. This session explores predictions across the Future of Working and also examines diverging future scenarios—from AI-driven productivity to AI-enabled human amplification. Attendees will be provided with tangible next steps to help them craft a future of work where both humans and organizations can thrive.

PRESENTERS:

Dr. Lauren S. Park
Quantitative Science Team Lead
SAP SuccessFactors

SPONSORS:

SAP SuccessFactors

JUN 9, 2026
10:45 am - 11:15 am PT
Leadership
Baden 1

Managing Humans in the Age of AI: The New People Playbook for HR and Leaders

This session explores how AI is reshaping people management and provides a practical playbook HR leaders and managers can apply immediately. Rather than revisiting what's already known, we focus on what actually works now: how to lead people more effectively in an AI-enabled workplace.

We'll cover five critical challenges redefining HR and leadership today, including:

- Rebuilding leadership competencies for an AI-augmented workforce
- Using AI to scale coaching, feedback, and development
- Bridging generational expectations through modern mentoring approaches
- Redefining performance management in a data-rich environment
- Maintaining human connection, trust, and culture amid automation

A core focus will be servant leadership as a competitive advantage—where leaders shift from directing work to enabling growth, removing barriers, and personalizing development at scale using AI tools. For example, leading organizations are now equipping managers with AI-driven coaching assistants that analyze employee feedback and suggest tailored development actions, allowing leaders to spend less time on administration and more time on meaningful engagement.

Attendees will leave with a clear, actionable framework for integrating AI into leadership development, mentoring, and daily management while strengthening the uniquely human skills that matter most. This session is designed for HR and business leaders who want to move from awareness to execution in building the next generation of leaders.

PRESENTERS:

Mark Monaghan
VP of Organizational Development
iQor

JUN 9, 2026
11:15 am - 11:45 am PT
HR Strategy/AI
Main Stage

Let's Build! Part 1: Ideation & Team Formation

Kick off the HRWest AI Hackathon by exploring real HR and workplace challenges where AI can create meaningful impact. No AI experience is required — this session is designed for everyone. Participants will form teams, choose a challenge track, and develop solution ideas while learning practical AI skills they can apply in their HR roles. By session end, teams will have a defined problem, solution concept, and development roadmap prepared for the next time they meet at Let's Build! Part 2.

PRESENTERS:

Debbie McGrath
CEO / Founder and Chief Instigator
HR.com

JUN 9, 2026
11:45 am - 1:00 pm PT
HR Strategy/AI

LUNCH OFF-SITE

Discover great local restaurants in the area for a lunch break.

PRESENTERS:

Debbie McGrath
CEO / Founder and Chief Instigator
HR.com

JUN 9, 2026
1:00 pm - 2:00 pm PT
HR Strategy/AI
Main Stage

The Meg & Amy Show Live — The Future of HR in an AI World

Meg & Amy are going to do a live podcast for the HRWest audience focusing on how the HR domain is changing in the AI era and how the role of HR needs to expand to meet the moment. As decades long HR product innovators and operators Meg & Amy have spent the last two years on the podcast talking to futurists, innovators, business and thought leaders and will share both what they have learned and what is still unclear. They balance deep curiosity with product expertise and intellectual humility in search of how to invent a future that is abundant and rich with opportunity and how to build the systems to thrive in the new world of work.

PRESENTERS:

Amy Wilson
CEO
Amy Wilson Advisory

Meg Bear
CEO & Strategic Advisor
Meg Bear Advisory

JUN 9, 2026
1:00 pm - 1:30 pm PT
Legal and Compliance
Oyster Room

Hot Topics in Employment Law and HR Compliance: Quick-Hit Updates

The employment law and HR landscape is evolving at an unprecedented pace. With major news headlines seemingly each week, it's more critical than ever to stay current. In this 30-minute session, Elizabeth Bille delivers a quick-hit briefing on key legal and policy developments affecting HR professionals today.

Designed for busy leaders, this session offers a high-level, targeted overview of workplace developments, highlighting what's changing, what matters now, and where to focus next.

Topics include:

1. EEOC priorities and reporting requirements, including the latest enforcement trends around "reverse discrimination" claims and developments related to EEO reporting
2. The current state of the DEI legal landscape, and what it means for employer programs and training
3. State workplace violence prevention laws and evolving employer obligations in California and beyond
4. AI in the workplace, including implications for workplace discrimination and harassment
5. Politics at work, including state restrictions on workplace communications and strategies for fostering inclusion across differences

For each topic, we'll cover:
- The headline update you need to know
- A practical takeaway
- Direction on where to go deeper for additional guidance

This session will ensure you leave with the latest developments firmly on your radar.

PRESENTERS:

Elizabeth Owens Bille
Executive Vice President & General Ma...
ComplyEQ

JUN 9, 2026
1:00 pm - 1:30 pm PT
Leadership
Baden 2

Psychological Safety + Radical Clarity: The Leadership Combo That Speeds Up Execution

Work is accelerating — hybrid realities, new tech, shifting expectations, and increasing diversity are making "old school" leadership models less effective by the day. In this fast, practical 30-minute session, you'll learn how modern leaders lead without needing to be the expert in the room — by creating clarity in ambiguity, empowering people to do their best work, and building cultures where innovation and trust thrive.

You'll leave with five immediately usable leadership micro-practices you can apply in your next meeting or 1:1: lead with curiosity (not certainty), build psychological safety on purpose, communicate with radical clarity, strengthen agility through quick experiments, and humanize the work experience so people feel seen. Expect simple prompts, phrases, and routines you can take straight back to your organization — no theory overload, just "do this on Monday."

What attendees will take away
- A set of curiosity-led questions (plus the 70/30 listening rule) that surface better ideas and reduces blind spots.
- Practical ways to build psychological safety (including a closing question that unlocks what's unsaid).
- A clarity + agility toolkit: explain the "why," confirm understanding, and make decisions with ~70% of the info to keep momentum.

PRESENTERS:

Emma Lidgett
Global Head of Talent Development an...
Kainos

JUN 9, 2026
1:00 pm - 1:30 pm PT
HR Tech
Baden 1

Digital Twins of Employees: Making the Most of Your Experts' Judgment

"The R&D guy who knows our product inside out is about to retire." "Our new hires need more support after formal onboarding." "Our execs are tired of answering the same questions hundreds of times."

The most valuable knowledge in an organization — the judgment, context, and unspoken rules your most in-demand people carry — rarely lives in a document. It lives in their heads, and it becomes unreachable when they're on the road, in a new role or time zone, or headed to retirement.

Learn how Digital Twins can capture that tacit knowledge and make it accessible to any teammate who needs it, subject to appropriate access controls — so progress doesn't stall when key people step away, and everyone can help their teammates even when they're not physically available.

PRESENTERS:

Anu Mangal
Product Marketing Manager
Viven

JUN 9, 2026
1:40 pm - 2:10 pm PT
Talent
Baden 1

The Hiring Funnel Is Collapsing: A Look at What's Next

For decades, hiring has followed the same seven-stage funnel — job posting, application, resume screen, phone screen, assessment, interview loop, offer. Most of those stages exist to manage scarcity and friction. But candidates are no longer scarce, and AI can now handle the busywork end to end. When that happens, the stages don't get faster. They stop being necessary — and that collapse is already underway.

PRESENTERS:

Mike Wood
Executive Community Leader, Talent A...
HR.com

JUN 9, 2026
1:40 pm - 2:10 pm PT
Legal and Compliance
Oyster Room

Employee Handbooks Do's and Don'ts – Shields, Traps, and Swords

Have you ever looked closely at your employee handbook?

Unwary employers may have terms that serve as traps, creating legal liability and employment claims. This presentation will address common red flags in employee handbooks and highlight the policies that employers that can serve as shields and swords when dealing with employment claims and disciplining employees.

PRESENTERS:

Conor J. Dale
Principal
Jackson Lewis P.C.

JUN 9, 2026
1:40 pm - 2:10 pm PT
Health, Wellness, Benefits
Baden 2

Substance Use, Mental Health, and Executive Risk: Hidden Liabilities in the Workplace

Organizations routinely plan for financial, legal, and operational risk, yet one of the most significant and least addressed threats to leadership continuity and organizational stability often remains unspoken: untreated substance use and co-occurring mental health challenges among executives and key personnel whose roles may be critical to organizational success.

At the highest level of business, a substance use disorder presents a unique paradox. Individuals in executive and key positions often have greater autonomy, resources, and influence, allowing challenges to be minimized, concealed, or accommodated for longer periods. When intervention does occur, it is frequently routed through high-cost, often "luxury" treatment environments that prioritize discretion and comfort, but may lack the accountability and longitudinal care required for sustained recovery. This can result in repeated treatment cycles, inconsistent performance, and ongoing organizational risk.

Drawing on decades of clinical experience treating high-functioning professionals, executives, and key organizational stakeholders, this presentation will examine how these conditions translate into material financial, operational, legal, and reputational liabilities for companies and how those liabilities can be mitigated by timely, skilled intervention.

This session is presented by the clinical team at Recovery Without Walls, an integrative outpatient medical practice specializing in addiction, chronic pain, and complex psychiatric care. The practice is led by Howard Kornfeld, MD, a nationally recognized addiction and pain specialist with more than four decades of clinical experience, including long-standing faculty involvement at UCSF and early leadership in compassionate outpatient treatment models. The broader team includes physicians, psychiatric providers, and care coordinators experienced in working with high-functioning professionals and executives requiring discretion, continuity, and highly individualized care.

PRESENTERS:

Howard Kornfeld, MD
Medical Director
Recovery Without Walls

Jacki Jones
Co-Founder
Zostera Partners

JUN 9, 2026
2:15 pm - 2:45 pm PT
Talent
Exhibit Hall

Certified Success: Insider Tips to Ace Your HR Exam

Preparing for an HR certification exam can feel overwhelming, but success is achievable with the right strategy, mindset, and preparation plan. This interactive roundtable session is designed for HR professionals pursuing HRCI or SHRM certifications who want practical guidance on how to confidently prepare for and pass their exams.

Attendees will explore proven study techniques, effective time-management strategies, and common mistakes that often derail candidates. The discussion will also provide insight into how certification exams are structured, which competencies are most heavily tested, and how to approach scenario-based questions with confidence.

The session will provide opportunities to share experiences, ask questions, and exchange best practices with peers who are also navigating the certification journey. Whether you are just beginning your preparation or looking for new strategies after a previous attempt, this discussion will deliver actionable takeaways to help you build confidence, reduce exam anxiety, and increase your chances of certification success.

PRESENTERS:

Jennifer Marants
Exam Preparation Course Designer an...
HR.com

JUN 9, 2026
2:15 pm - 2:45 pm PT
Talent
Exhibit Hall

Cut Through the Noise: The Two Human Signals That Drive Engagement, Retention, and Performance

More innovation does not equal more engagement.
Across industries, leaders are navigating increased complexity, information, tools, and expectations- yet many organizations continue to struggle with disengagement, turnover, and inconsistent performance.
This session cuts through the noise.
Rather than introducing another program, platform, or trend, this practical and research-informed workshop focuses on two human signals that consistently drive motivation, retention, and discretionary effort - across roles, industries, and generations. When leaders understand and intentionally manage these signals, engagement improves, workforce challenges simplify, and performance conversations become more effective and productive.
Designed for senior leaders and HR professionals alike, this session delivers a clear, human-centered framework that can be applied immediately - helping leaders strengthen accountability, align expectations, and create the conditions where engaged people perform at a higher level, internally motivated to do their best.
If you're looking for clarity instead of complexity, this session offers a focused perspective that makes today's workplace easier to understand and manage.

PRESENTERS:

Melanie Jones
Performance Specialist
Insperity

JUN 9, 2026
2:15 pm - 2:45 pm PT
Leadership
Exhibit Hall

Are Your Successors Actually Ready? Building Governance Into Succession Planning

Many organizations have succession plans, but fewer have confidence that their named successors are truly ready. Readiness is often based on manager opinion, informal calibration, or outdated role assumptions rather than on clear, governed evidence. As leadership expectations shift and workforce risk increases, HR teams need a more defensible way to identify, evaluate, and develop successors.

This roundtable will explore how organizations can strengthen succession planning by defining what readiness means, aligning successors with future role requirements, using evidence to identify gaps, and building governance into talent decisions. Participants will discuss how to move beyond names in boxes toward a more transparent, consistent, and actionable succession process.

PRESENTERS:

Linda Ginac
CEO
TalentGuard

JUN 9, 2026
2:15 pm - 2:45 pm PT
HR Strategy/AI
Exhibit Hall

HR Strategists in a World of AI Agents

The executive suite often wants two things: HR to become more strategic and the organization to better leverage AI. In this roundtable, we'll discuss the intersection of these two trends. We'll start off with some recent HR.com research data, but this will mostly be a chance to chat with fellow HR professionals about how HR strategies are likely to evolve over the next two years.

PRESENTERS:

Mark Vickers
Chief Research Analyst & Data Wrangler
HR.com

JUN 9, 2026
2:15 pm - 2:45 pm PT
Talent
Oyster Room

TA Vendor CEOs on Hiring's Next Chapter

Hiring tech is being rewritten in real time. Application volume has exploded, AI sits on both sides of the desk, and the old assumptions about how candidates and companies find each other no longer hold. So what are the people actually building these tools seeing from the inside?

In this candid CEO panel, founders of leading talent acquisition platforms sit down to talk about the shifting dynamics reshaping how organizations hire. We'll dig into where the traditional process is breaking down, how they're rethinking it from the ground up, and the hard choices they're making as AI moves from buzzword to baseline. Expect a frank conversation about what's hype, what's real, and where hiring goes from here — straight from the people betting their companies on the answers.

PRESENTERS:

Aaron Wang
CEO & Co-Founder
Alex AI (fka Apriora)

Claire McTaggart
Founder & CEO
SquarePeg Hires

Mike Wood
Executive Community Leader, Talent A...
HR.com

JUN 9, 2026
2:15 pm - 2:45 pm PT
HR Strategy/AI
Exhibit Hall

AI Transformation: How Companies Are Redefining Careers, Skills & Community at Work

As AI rapidly transforms the workplace, organizations are rethinking how they develop and support their people. Traditional job structures are evolving into more dynamic, skills-based models as AI reshapes work, automates tasks, and changes the capabilities companies need from their workforce. Careers are increasingly shifting from static roles to more fluid experiences built around projects, gigs, internal mobility, and continuous learning.

At the same time, the human side of work is becoming more important—not less. As employees navigate rapid change, organizations are investing more heavily in communities, peer learning, and personalized support systems that help people adapt, grow, and stay connected. This session explores how leading companies are redefining careers, skills, and workplace community in the age of AI — and why human connection may become one of the most strategic advantages in an AI-powered future.

PRESENTERS:

Phil George
CEO
MentorcliQ

JUN 9, 2026
2:15 pm - 2:45 pm PT
Talent
Exhibit Hall

The Elegant Simplicity of Diversity, Equity, Inclusion and Belonging

Based on my knowledge, experience, and expertise, I wrote and published an article focusing on a different approach to DEI in the current anti-DEI climate. I bring a fresh perspective on how DEI efforts can succeed, while quelling the cries from anti-DEI activists. I encourage my fellow DEI activists to take a leap of faith and assume positive intent behind anti-DEI movements, to arrive at a place where reasoned discussions can lead to positive outcomes. My article will form the basis for the roundtable discussion.

Through first-hand observations and considered references, I journey through the root causes of DEI and anti-DEI activism. I discuss the historical origins of DEI efforts. Importantly, I also discuss some of the failures of DEI efforts which have spawned anti-DEI activism, in order to frame my novel but straightforward approach which is anchored in: Discipline, Honesty and Courage. Finally, I offer practical ways to achieve success.

In my article, I discuss real life examples where a lack of Discipline, Honesty and Courage can fuel DEI or Anti-DEI activism. For the purposes of the session, I will expand on and convert these examples into case studies for discussion and ultimately for participants to share how they would approach each.

Finally, as a takeaway for all attendees, I will provide a copy of Toni Morrison's short story Recitatif, which explores how beliefs about racial characteristics can color one's view about a particular individual. This thought-provoking piece remains intentionally silent with regards to the protagonists' racial identities (though notes that one is white and one is Black) and encourages readers to examine racial stereotypes to hopefully dispel them.

PRESENTERS:

Christina Herrmann
Chief People Officer
Independent Executive Consultant

JUN 9, 2026
2:15 pm - 2:45 pm PT
HR Strategy/AI
Exhibit Hall

The AI Co-Pilot Dilemma: Maintaining Human Accountability in High-Stakes HR Decisions

AI tools are rapidly becoming the "co-pilots" for everyday HR decisions, from screening resumes to drafting performance reviews. But when an AI tool flags a candidate or scores an employee, where does the machine's influence end and your judgment begin?

This fast-paced, 30-minute roundtable is designed for HR professionals at all levels who want to look past the marketing hype and understand the real-world friction between human intuition and algorithmic data. We will discuss the invisible risks of over-relying on automated recommendations, such as automation bias: trusting the data over our own judgment, and how to maintain meaningful human oversight. You will walk away with practical, immediate questions to ask your technology vendors and a simple framework to help ensure your team retains the final, compliant say in high-stakes talent decisions.

PRESENTERS:

Frank Ginac
CAIO
TalentGuard

JUN 9, 2026
2:15 pm - 2:45 pm PT
HR Strategy/AI
Exhibit Hall

Helping Organizational Leadership Understand 'Future Value' in Payroll

Payroll sits at the center of the employment relationship, yet the way organizations measure its impact remains narrowly defined. Most leadership teams still view payroll through the lens of cost, efficiency, and compliance. These metrics are at once precise, defensible, and deeply incomplete. This bias toward what is easily measured obscures payroll's growing influence on trust, retention, workforce stability, and overall organizational performance.

This session challenges the prevailing financial and operational frameworks that limit how payroll's value is understood. It introduces three practical ways payroll leaders can help executive stakeholders see beyond cost accounting and begin recognizing payroll as a driver of future value:

-> First, we reframe efficiency as a starting point, not an outcome. We do so by exposing how traditional metrics capture immediate financial outputs while missing downstream effects on engagement, performance, and retention.

-> Second, we explore how to translate payroll's impact into the language of finance without losing its human dimension, bridging the gap between GAAP-aligned reporting and the realities of workforce value creation.

-> Third, we examine how payroll data, when connected to broader workforce and business outcomes, can tell a more complete story about the conditions under which employees do their best work.

Attendees will leave with a clearer understanding of why payroll's most strategic contributions often go unrecognized and how to change that narrative. More importantly, they will gain a practical framework for helping leadership account not just for what payroll costs, but for what it makes possible.

PRESENTERS:

Brent Skinner
Executive Community Leader, Payroll | ...
HR.com

JUN 9, 2026
2:15 pm - 2:45 pm PT
HR Strategy/AI
Exhibit Hall

Leading People Through AI Integration with Trust and Transparency

We're not just leading people. We're leading humans through one of the biggest shifts in how work gets done in our lifetime, without a blueprint.

This roundtable discussion provides a collaborative space to explore strategies for leading AI integration through a human-centered lens. When implementing AI, many organizations are approaching it as a tech rollout, when it is a significant organizational change event like a merger and/or acquisition with all the big feelings that go along with it.

At the core of successful adoption is a critical truth. Adoption is an emotional decision before it is a logical one. If employees don't feel safe, informed, and supported, they are less likely to engage with new tools or ways of working. This session will focus on how leaders can address employee concerns, including fear of job loss, while driving performance and innovation while meeting the company's KPIs.

Through shared insights and practical strategies, this session will examine how leaders can balance urgency with empathy, implement phased and sustainable approaches to AI integration, and create environments where employees feel supported, informed, and empowered to adapt.

By reframing AI as a people-first transformation rather than a systems implementation, leaders can create an environment where employees feel secure and engaged, ultimately strengthening adoption, retention, and organizational resilience.

PRESENTERS:

Necco Stevens
Experience Consultant
uNēc Consulting

JUN 9, 2026
2:15 pm - 2:45 pm PT
HR Tech
Exhibit Hall

Building a Smarter HR Function Through People Analytics and AI

As organizations accelerate their digital transformation journeys, HR is evolving from a process-driven function into a strategic, insight-led partner to the business. This roundtable explores how people analytics and artificial intelligence are reshaping the way HR teams make decisions, design workforce strategies, and deliver employee experiences at scale.

We will discuss how HR leaders can move beyond traditional reporting to build a truly data-driven function, leveraging predictive analytics, AI-powered insights, and real-time workforce intelligence. The conversation will also highlight practical use cases across talent acquisition, workforce planning, performance, and employee engagement, along with the cultural and capability shifts required to make analytics actionable.

PRESENTERS:

Rajan Sahni
Sr Manager, Global P&C Tech and Anal...
Playlist

JUN 9, 2026
2:15 pm - 2:45 pm PT
Talent
Exhibit Hall

Are We Automating Ourselves Into a Worse Hiring Process?

Automation and AI feel like they are taking over our processes, but at what cost? It seems as though hiring teams have never had more tools at their disposal from AI screening, automated outreach, scheduling bots, assessments, chat-based candidate experiences, and analytics dashboards for everything. In theory, this should have made hiring faster, smoother, and more consistent. And yet... most teams would still describe their process as slow, messy, and harder than it should be.

This roundtable will debate the assumption that technology always equals better outcomes. When does the automation of screening and evaluating candidates or our employees improve the experience and when are we just accelerating a flawed process? Participants will discuss where automation is improving the candidate and hiring manager experience, and where it is introducing friction and disengagement. How do we leverage the benefits without risking hiring bias, reduced engagement, or a negative impact on quality?

We will take a candid look at where 'innovation' is raising the bar and where it is putting a Band-Aid on issues that actually need to be fixed. Instead of whispering about it, this conversation will cover specific examples of the good, the bad, and the ugly, and aim to identify where the real wins are between all the hype.

PRESENTERS:

Raleen Gagnon
VP, Growth & Strategy
Pyramid Consulting, Inc

JUN 9, 2026
2:15 pm - 2:45 pm PT
HR Tech
Baden 1

Do You Have the Right Flight Crew?

Organizations invest heavily in systems, strategies, and transformation initiatives... yet many still, not because of technology, but because the wrong people are in the wrong seats, or the right people lack shared clarity.

In Do You Have the Right Flight Crew?, Lee reframes organizational transformation as a flight: success depends on who's in the cockpit, who's navigating, who's maintaining the aircraft, and who's communicating with passengers.

This interactive session invites attendees to examine their own "crew" across HR, Talent, and Technology, identify friction points, and leave with a practical framework they can immediately apply to transformation efforts, implementations, and operating models.

Grab your boarding pass, find your seat, and take flight.

PRESENTERS:

Lee Cage
Director, Enterprise Transformation, Str...
BDO USA

JUN 9, 2026
2:15 pm - 2:45 pm PT
Leadership
Exhibit Hall

Leading Through Uncertainty: Building Organizational Resilience in Volatile Times

In an era marked by rapid technological disruption, economic volatility, and evolving workforce expectations, HR leaders must cultivate organizational resilience while maintaining employee engagement and business continuity. This roundtable explores how senior HR professionals can develop adaptive leadership strategies that prepare their organizations to not just survive, but thrive amid constant change.

Participants will examine practical frameworks for building psychological safety, fostering agile decision-making processes, and creating communication strategies that maintain trust during turbulent periods. The discussion will delve into real-world case studies where HR leaders successfully navigated major organizational transformations, including restructurings, mergers, and sudden market shifts. We'll explore how to balance the need for stability with the imperative for innovation, and how to develop leadership capabilities at all organizational levels that embrace ambiguity rather than resist it.

This collaborative session encourages participants to share their own experiences leading through disruption, discuss common pitfalls, and co-create solutions for maintaining organizational coherence when traditional playbooks no longer apply. Together, we'll explore how HR can serve as the strategic anchor that keeps organizations grounded while remaining flexible enough to pivot quickly when circumstances demand it.

PRESENTERS:

Dr. Jonathan H. Westover
Associate Dean and Director of HR Aca...
Western Governors University

JUN 9, 2026
2:15 pm - 2:45 pm PT
HR Strategy/AI
Exhibit Hall

Rising Above the AI Fog: Workforce Readiness & Responsible GenAI in HR

HRWest 2026 is themed around "Rising Above the Fog" — finding clarity and purpose in turbulent times — at a time when HR leaders are being asked to do more with less and make smart calls on critical issues like AI.

This facilitated roundtable gives HR, Talent and L&D leaders a structured way to compare what's working (and what's risky) as GenAI and emerging "agentic AI" capabilities enter HR workflows. Participants will share real examples, pressure-test governance and adoption approaches, and leave with a simple, immediately usable "AI readiness" plan grounded in the priorities many HR teams are focusing on for 2026 (workforce readiness, operating model changes, and AI fluency).

PRESENTERS:

Emma Lidgett
Global Head of Talent Development an...
Kainos

JUN 9, 2026
2:15 pm - 2:45 pm PT
Leadership
Exhibit Hall

The Questions Nobody Asks...Until the Culture Change Fails

Let's be honest, most culture change efforts don't fail because of a bad strategy. They fail because nobody stopped to ask whether the organization was ready before the initiative launched.

I've seen it happen more times than I can count. Leaders get energized, a new values framework gets rolled out, the engagement survey goes live, and a year later, nothing has really shifted. Not because people didn't care, but because the hard questions never got asked upfront.

That's what this roundtable is about — not a framework, not a presentation, but a real conversation among experienced HR leaders about what readiness for culture change looks like, and how the questions we ask (or avoid) early on can make or break the whole effort.
What does it mean for leaders to be truly aligned versus just enthusiastic?

How do you find out what's really going on when people don't feel safe enough to tell you the truth?

And what do we do when the culture we're trying to build is still being undermined by the systems we haven't fixed yet?

Here's what I've learned: culture change doesn't stick unless people feel connected to it, and that means they have to feel like they belong to the organization that's asking them to change. When employees don't see themselves in the future being described, when they don't feel a genuine stake in the outcome, even the best-designed initiative will fall flat. Belonging isn't a feel-good add-on to culture work. It's the foundation that makes change possible.

I've been in these trenches, and I'm guessing you have too. Let's learn from each other.

Everyone who joins will walk away with a Culture Readiness Question Bank: a practical set of diagnostic questions you can use back at work, not just something that sits in your conference folder.

PRESENTERS:

Rosalind Cohen
CEO/Founder
Socius Strategies LLC

JUN 9, 2026
2:50 pm - 3:20 pm PT
HR Tech
Baden 1

Next Gen Talent Acquisition – Reimagining Your End-to-End TA Tech Stack

This session explores how to move from fragmented recruiting tools to an integrated, skills aware AI-powered talent ecosystem that supports the full journey from candidate to employee. Critical topics include unifying data across ATS, HRIS, and CRM, embedding AI for sourcing and matching, and setting governance for ethical, explainable automation.

PRESENTERS:

Deepti Chaudhary
Sr. HRIS Manager
Dover Corporation

JUN 9, 2026
2:50 pm - 3:20 pm PT
Talent
Baden 2

Culture Reset: When Values Exist—but Behaviors Drift

This session explores a common but often unspoken challenge: when an organization's stated values remain intact, yet day-to-day behaviors quietly drift. Dismissive communication, inconsistent leadership practices, unclear expectations, and unresolved tension rarely appear immediately in engagement surveys, but over time they erode trust, performance, and psychological safety.

In this fast-paced, practical session, attendees will learn how to recognize early warning signs of cultural drift before it escalates into disengagement, turnover, or performance problems. Drawing on real-world leadership experience, this session reframes a "culture reset" not as a morale initiative or rebranding effort, but as a behavioral and leadership alignment process.

Participants will be introduced to clear, actionable tools people leaders can use immediately, including expectation-setting frameworks, feedback standards, and leader accountability practices that reinforce clarity, respect, and consistency. The focus is on helping leaders reset norms without overcorrecting, creating fear, or defaulting to punitive approaches, especially during periods of pressure or change.

Attendees will leave with practical strategies to stabilize culture, realign leadership behaviors with stated values, and support leaders in modeling the behaviors the organization truly expects.

PRESENTERS:

Theresa Parra
Executive Director, People & Developm...
Netafim USA

JUN 9, 2026
2:50 pm - 3:20 pm PT
HR Strategy/AI
Main Stage

The Human-Centered World in the Age of Intelligence

Population and generational shifts will create demand for agentic technology use at an accelerated pace. Human Resources is traditionally slower to adapt to change as a function, but over the next two years HR will need to be at the forefront of that change or find that it is an obsolete function in the Agentic Age.

We will look at the changes ahead globally and an exploration of how the end of the Industrial Age, driven by AI agents, will lead to a more human-centric world of work. This shift will redefine how organizations operate, placing greater emphasis on creativity, empathy, collaboration, and uniquely human skills as automation takes on more routine and transactional tasks.

PRESENTERS:

Nancy Hauge
Chief People Experience Officer
Automation Anywhere

JUN 9, 2026
2:50 pm - 3:20 pm PT
Leadership
Oyster Room

Women in Leadership Panel — Navigating the New Frontier: Women Leading Through Economic and Labor Shifts

1. The "Flexibility Stigma" & The Return-to-Office (RTO) Backlash

While over 60% of women cite workplace flexibility as the single biggest factor for their career sustainability, companies are aggressively rolling back hybrid and remote policies. Crucially, recent data reveals a massive "flexibility stigma": **women who work remotely are being penalized with fewer promotions and sponsorships, while men who work remotely face no such penalty. ***

The Angle: How to maintain visibility, secure sponsorship, and advance while utilizing flexible work models.

2. GenAI and the "AI Upskilling Gap"

Artificial Intelligence is rapidly reshaping job functions, but an unexpected gender gap has emerged. Men are currently receiving more encouragement and structured training to use generative AI tools at work, while entry- and mid-level women are being left out.

The Angle: Ensuring women are not left behind in the tech revolution and actively leveraging AI to automate routine tasks.

3. Disrupted "Superwoman" Narratives & Burnout

The data is staggering: nearly **6 in 10 senior-level women report frequent burnout**—significantly higher than their male peers. A massive theme at conferences this year is "Disrupting the Superwoman Narrative" and prioritizing nervous system regulation and rest as actual leadership skills, rather than over-functioning until collapse.

The Angle: Redefining leadership as shared power and sustainable boundaries rather than self-sacrifice.

4. The Declining DEI Commitment & The "Broken Rung"

For the first time in a decade, corporate commitment to gender diversity is stalling or actively rolling back (e.g., cutting formal mentorship, scaling back bias training). Meanwhile, the "broken rung"—the barrier preventing women from making the first step from entry-level to manager—remains firmly in place, particularly for women of color.

The Angle: How to advocate for yourself and others when formal corporate diversity programs are shrinking.

PRESENTERS:

Debbie McGrath
CEO / Founder and Chief Instigator
HR.com

Elizabeth Owens Bille
Executive Vice President & General Ma...
ComplyEQ

Kelley Steven-Waiss
Founder & CEO
Novaworks, Inc.

JUN 9, 2026
3:20 pm - 4:30 pm PT
HR Strategy/AI
Exhibit Hall

Expo Time

Take some time to visit exhibit tables and connect with other attendees!

PRESENTERS:

Debbie McGrath
CEO / Founder and Chief Instigator
HR.com

JUN 9, 2026
4:30 pm - 5:00 pm PT
Talent
Main Stage

Innovative Techniques for Bridging the Generation Gap at Work

We live in a very divided world. One of those divisions is the generation gap. Today's workplaces can include 3 or 4 generations, who often struggle to understand each other, creating tension at work that is counterproductive. This workshop uses innovative, interactive exercises to help participants explore their hidden biases and discover new ways of connecting across generational and cultural barriers. Participants will leave with increased understanding of generational differences, as well as insights about finding common ground and concrete tools for connecting across the age spectrum in the workplace.

PRESENTERS:

Yael Schy
Founder
Zoomers to Boomers Improv

JUN 9, 2026
5:00 pm - 5:45 pm PT
HR Strategy/AI
Exhibit Hall

Reception

Wrap up the first day of HRWest 2026 at our Opening Reception! After a full day of learning, join fellow attendees, speakers, exhibitors, and industry leaders for more networking and conversation. Enjoy complimentary drinks and light appetizers while making new connections, sharing insights from the day, and preparing for another exciting day of sessions ahead.

PRESENTERS:

Debbie McGrath
CEO / Founder and Chief Instigator
HR.com